

SY: Page 1 – Philosophy of Creative engagement

Goal: shifting the focus from “what is true” to “what is possible.” We want to relieve the pressure of memory.

What is creativity, what does it emphasize

Creativity here doesn’t mean coming up with something so original or novel. In this space, creativity is simply the action of expressing something, emphasizing imagination over accuracy. Move away from the idea of “testing” the seniors and think of it more as building something together with them.

Why engagement matters

Engagement tries to counter the feeling of isolation that often comes with memory loss. When we engage creatively, we give people back their agency and a sense of purpose.

Brief dementia facts

While dementia often impacts short-term memory and linear thinking, the capacity for imagination and emotional resonance remains incredibly strong. With TimeSlips, we are tapping into what is still there in their imagination.



CORE PRINCIPLES OF TIMESLIPS FOR VOLUNTEERS

Key Ideas

An open mindset is core to creative engagement activities. It's important to remember to focus on and encourage people's imaginations, and that there are no wrong answers. A good way to remember this is "yes, and" thinking. This type of thinking emphasizes opening yourself to wonder, validating people's feelings and their meaning.

Examples of good ways to facilitate creative storytelling are 1.) asking beautiful questions (open-ended inquiries to spark creativity and thinking), and 2.) echoing people's responses to demonstrate that you're actively listening to them.

Individual vs. Group Storytelling

Both individual and group stories work; you can choose which type of storytelling to incorporate into your session depending on what you're looking for and/or what others would prefer.

Individual stories are perfect if the person you're working with prefers more control over the session, and enjoys using their imagination to create a story of greater depth. However, this option may not go as well if the person you're working with is hesitant or isn't very engaged with the activity.

Alternatively, group storytelling can work well because it helps reinforce a sense of community among participants, and is often more playful and funny, as long as the group can collaborate effectively.



SY: Page 3 – running creative engagement session

What you need to facilitate a session

Keep it minimal. A compelling, slightly ambiguous prompt (like a quirky photograph or an interesting object), a quiet and comfortable space, an open mind, and if possible, even something to write their ideas down on (so they see their words have value).

Specific steps

1. Introduce yourself, pass around the image/object, and you could add a sentence like, “There are no wrong answers” if it makes them feel more comfortable.
2. Ask a broad opening question to get the ball rolling.
3. Ask follow-up questions based on what they say. If possible, record their answers visible to the group.
4. Read the imaginative, beautiful story back to them to celebrate what you built together.

Types of questions (sensory, who/what/where/when, etc)

- The 5 Ws: Who is the person in this picture? What are they hiding in their pocket? Where are they running to?
- Sensory: If we stepped into this picture, what would it smell like? Is it cold out there? What song is playing in the background?

Tips for communication

- The “Yes, and...” Rule: Accept absolutely every answer. If someone says the dog in the picture is flying, try to roll with it. (“A flying dog! Where is it flying to?”)
- Give them plenty of time to process the question and answer.
- Sit at eye level, maintain warm eye contact, and project your voice clearly without shouting.



BEAUTIFUL QUESTIONS

The purpose of asking beautiful questions is to encourage people's imaginations and promote creativity in storytelling, rather than testing someone's memory or knowledge. Beautiful questions are prompts that:

- are open-ended
- have no right or wrong answers
- Invite curiosity and unique expression



Sensory Questions

- What do you first notice in this image?
- What does the air smell like?
- Is it warm or cold in this place?
- What sounds are happening here?



Storybuilding Questions

- Who is this person, what is his name?
 - What's he doing here?
- What happened just before the moment this picture was taken?
 - What might happen next?

Example Image



Sample Questions

- Who might this person be waiting for?
- Where could they be traveling?
- What do you think is inside his luggage?

Page 5: video of creative engagement session (5 min)

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1qKk2wtcWrTWAVjlgUQ8rMZzhOHJ7YZ5C/view>

Note: in the video, Brendan is standing up and talking to the resident looking down (for video setup purposes). In real one-on-one timeslips sessions, it would be more ideal to be **eye-level with the resident**. This allows for a more comfortable, personal environment.

Key Techniques Used by Brendan (take note of these when watching the demonstration):

1. The open-ended name prompt: “So this man, what do you think his name could be? If you could pick anything.”
 - a. Brendan didn't provide a list of names, but he gave John total creative freedom. This led to John choosing “Robert,” which immediately gave him a sense of ownership over the story.
2. Building on Non-Visual Details (Yes, And): “He's a businessman trying to sell newspapers? Definitely. I can see them for sure.”
 - a. When John suggested Robert was a businessman selling newspapers, Brendan validated that “vision” immediately. He then pointed to a physical detail in the photo (the newspaper) to ground John's imaginary idea in reality.
3. Sensory Expansion (Music & Mood): “I'm noticing that there's a jukebox right in the background here... what type of music do you think Robert would enjoy listening to?”
 - a. By shifting from what Robert was *doing* to what he was *hearing*, Brendan opened up a new sensory layer that involves sound and music. This allowed John to bring in a specific artist (Kenny) and deepened his immersion in the character.
4. Encouraging Narrative Action: “So do you think Robert gets his ideas maybe from what he sees when he's outside of nature? Is that something that's possible?”
 - a. Brendan used a leading but open question to help John connect two different parts of the story (Nature and the Newspaper). This prompted John to come up with the specific detail of Robert watching kids play sports for inspiration.